

Big Red Kangaroo

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Source: `Big Red Kangaroo.pdf` (36 PDF pages; story on PDF pages 9-29, information page 31) with garbled passages verified against the companion teacher-text file `BIG RED KANGAROO - text.pdf`

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Far inland, where ocean is a dim memory, the sun floats on the waves of another bake-earth day. In the long shadows, a big red kangaroo licks his forearms and lets the early evening breeze wash over him.

This is Red. He appears relaxed, almost lazy, but if you watch closely, you'll see his ears twitch. He is alert. Around him, females, joeys and young kangaroos also stir. This is his mob.

Red kangaroos live in families called mobs. The groups usually contain a dominant male, at least one female and several joeys (baby kangaroos). Like all families, group size varies.

The heat eases with approaching nightfall. It is breakfast time for Red's mob. Around them, the night orchestra begins. Red rises and leads his mob beyond the shadow line in search of grasses.

Red kangaroos are most active at dusk and dawn, although they will graze throughout the night. The grasses are difficult for their stomachs to digest. When they rest, they sometimes regurgitate their food and chew it again.

A sudden storm rinses the air and sweeps dust into mud rivulets. Red flattens his body, extends his tail and bounds tree-ward, his mob close behind.

A kangaroo's tail is long and strong. It works almost as another leg when slow-hopping or standing still. When a kangaroo moves at full speed, its tail acts like a rudder and helps with balance.

Other groups of kangaroos join them in the shelter of the trees. Red watches. A young male wanders too close to Red's mob. Red stands proud, shoulders back. It is a warning. The young kangaroo hops away. He is no threat today.

Each mob has a single strong male as leader. If he shows signs of weakness, other males will challenge his position to become the head of the mob. A full-grown male red kangaroo can weigh as much as ninety kilograms and may reach 1.8 metres in height when standing.

The rain ends as suddenly as it began and the kangaroos venture out again. Rainwater loiters in shallow pools and Red drinks. The mob is joined by wallaroos, thorny devils and a spinifex hopping mouse. There is not much water here in the middle of the land, in the middle of the dry season.

Kangaroos get most of their water from the plants they eat, but they will drink from puddles and streams if they can. When the season is good and food is plentiful, they may not drink much water at all.

Red cannot settle while other males are so close. It is time to move. He sets off east, his mob close behind. His hops are long. Each landing pushes air from his lungs, each bound fills them.

When red kangaroos want to travel faster, they make each hop longer, rather than take more hops. This conserves their energy so they can travel long distances.

Red halts at a broad, shallow plain that sits lower than the surrounding land. This depression caught a shower last week and now blushes green in the moonlight. Red sniffs the air, listens, then settles to eat. Tuft by green tuft, he chews and swallows. The night is alive with stars. Animals too. Most Red can ignore. Only dingo is dangerous, with his stealth and sharp teeth.

Red kangaroos have few natural predators. Large goannas sometimes take young joeys in the daytime. When the earth cools, goannas move more slowly and it is night-hunting dingoes that are more dangerous.

Other mobs arrive. A male moves closer and closer. Red stops eating. He must challenge or be challenged. Red stretches tall. The other male matches him. They stare at each other. Sometimes this is enough, but not this time. Young adult males may live in a mob of their own. They will play fight with other kangaroos until they are experienced enough to challenge the leader of a mob.

Red pushes up on his toes, braces against his tail. He tips his head back and lashes out, first one paw then the other. The other male strikes too, but wildly. Red's next hit will end it. The challenger retreats, all fight gone from him. Fights for dominance can be fierce but are usually brief. The loser will withdraw before either kangaroo is really hurt.

Red traverses the open plains with his mob. As the sun tips across the horizon, he returns to the trees. They will offer shade and shelter through the sizzle-bright day. His belly is full. His mob is safe. Red is king of his world. For now.

When a male kangaroo is no longer the biggest or strongest, his mob will follow a new leader. This gives the mob the best chance of survival in a harsh environment.

Information About Red Kangaroos: Kangaroos are found only in Australia and Papua New Guinea. They are a diverse family, with more than sixty different species, and live in a wide range of habitats from wet rainforests through to dry plains. Kangaroos are marsupials -- their young are born undeveloped and then continue to grow in their mothers' pouches. Their family name "macropod" means "big foot". The biggest of all macropods is the red kangaroo. They live in the hot, dry inland of Australia where food can be scarce and water even more so.

- The opening spreads show Red in long evening shadows, licking his forearms, ears twitching, with his mob of females, joeys and young kangaroos stirring around him (per prose cues; not pixel-verified).
- The middle spreads show the night grazing, the sudden storm and bounding flight tree-ward, the shelter of the trees with wallaroos, thorny devils and hopping mouse at the pools, and the warning stance against the young male.
- The closing spreads show the moonlit green plain, the dominance fight braced on tails, and the dawn return to the trees (per prose cues; not pixel-verified).

Story text verified against two sources: the main PDF's embedded text layer (story on PDF pages 9-29, information page 31) and the companion teacher-text file, which matches the main-PDF fragments word for word. Passages where the main PDF's custom font drops glyphs were completed from the companion file; wording is identical in every checkable fragment. Narrative paragraphs are presented as flowing prose with the factual side panels in italics. Dedication, imprint/copyright matter (pages 6-7), back-matter advertisements and the

unrelated preview pages (34-36) are not included as story prose. Pixel-level visual verification against the rendered scans has not yet been completed -- my image-reading tool is currently unavailable, so please check the transcript against the PDF before treating it as final.